

# M. Dalbert Ma

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| INTERESTS | AI & Organizations, Human–AI Interaction, Organizational Design, Digital Strategy |
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| EDUCATION | <b>London Business School</b> , PhD in Strategy & Entrepreneurship | 2027 |
|           | <b>IESE Business School</b> , MSc in Management                    | 2020 |
|           | <b>Pompeu Fabra University</b> , LLM in Law & Economics            | 2019 |
|           | <b>University of York</b> , BA in Philosophy, Politics & Economics | 2018 |

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| JOB MARKET<br>PAPER | <p>[1] <b>Ma, M.D.</b> The Organizational Tradeoff of AI Coordination: Evidence from a Container Port</p> <p><b>Abstract:</b> Since Simon (1947), theories of the firm have explained how limits on attention, memory, and computation constrain how much interdependent activity can be placed under common control. Artificial intelligence (AI) can relax these information-processing constraints by optimizing over states represented in its training data. I study the organizational consequences of delegating coordination to such a system at one of the world's largest container terminals, which preserves a rare counterfactual: the same AI dispatches the same autonomous fleet through zones it controls almost entirely and zones shared with independent human-driven trucks. Across 179,925 tasks over 364 days, I compare AI-dominant and mixed human-AI zones under ordinary operation, recurrent disruptions, and a disruption unprecedented in the terminal's history. In ordinary operation, AI-dominant zones sustain 18 percent more crane work per vehicle; the advantage survives recurrent disruptions despite longer delays, but reverses under the unprecedented one: AI-dominant zones produce less output than mixed zones. To interpret these findings, I develop a model showing why the configuration maximizing expected output under the historical distribution need not do so when it changes. These results show that a firm delegating coordination to AI optimizes for the states it has experienced and may trade away its capacity for those it has not.</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• <i>Awards (2026)</i>: AOM Robert J. Litschert Best Doctoral Student Paper Award; AOM STR Best Paper Award; William H. Newman Dissertation Award Finalist; SMS Best Paper Prize Nominee</li><li>• <i>Selected Presentations (2026)</i>: Wharton WINDS, MIT Business Implications of GenAI, Columbia Business School ECDC, Duke Strategy PhD Conference, CCC, Harvard AI Institute OUI Conference, Academy of Management, Oxford ISA, Strategic Management Society</li></ul> |
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| WORKING<br>PAPERS | <p>[2] Jacobides, M.G., <b>Ma, M.D.</b>, Das, A., Iyer, S., &amp; Langione, M. Generative AI and the Architecture of Knowledge Work: Expertise Bypass, Exchange Governability, and Shifting Bottlenecks. <i>Conditionally Accepted, Strategic Entrepreneurship Journal</i></p> <p>[3] Jacobides, M.G. &amp; <b>Ma, M.D.</b> What Are Generative AI's Competitive Implications? A Longitudinal Documentation of Director Expectations. <i>Preparing for submission to Management Science</i></p> <p>[4] <b>Ma, M.D.</b>, Brahm, F., &amp; Sun, S. The Value of Human-in-the-Loop: Evidence from Self-Driving Logistics. <i>Preparing for submission to Management Science</i></p> <p>[5] Jacobides, M.G. &amp; <b>Ma, M.D.</b> Realizing Physical and Digital Synergies in Multi-Business Firms: A Configurational Approach. <i>Preparing for submission to Organization Science</i></p> |
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| WORK IN<br>PROGRESS          | [6] <b>Ma, M.D.</b> & Vakili, K. Generative AI and the Shifting Locus of Innovation: Start-ups, Incumbents, and Programming Consolidation. <i>Data analysis in progress; IEPC-funded.</i>                                                                |           |
|                              | [7] <b>Ma, M.D.</b> , Puntoni, S., & Jacobides, M.G. Generative AI and Schumpeterian Competition: Shifting Logics in Technological Regimes. <i>Draft in preparation; Wharton AI &amp; Analytics-funded.</i>                                              |           |
|                              | [8] McElheran, K. & <b>Ma, M.D.</b> Task Interdependence, Causal Ambiguity, and the Attribution of AI's Value: Evidence from a Team-Production Experiment. <i>In design; experimental platform built.</i>                                                |           |
|                              | [9] Clarke, R. & <b>Ma, M.D.</b> AI Agents and Entrepreneurial Performance: A National Rollout of an AI Operating System. <i>In design; implementation partner secured.</i>                                                                              |           |
| PRACTITIONER<br>PUBLICATIONS | [10] <b>Ma, M.D.</b> , Clarke, R., & Cheng, E.Y. Where Do Exceptions Go? Generative AI and Knowledge Hierarchies Inside Firms: Evidence from Enterprise Telemetry. <i>In design; data partnership secured.</i>                                           |           |
|                              | [11] Jacobides, M.G., <b>Ma, M.D.</b> , Trantopoulos, K., & Vassalos, V. 2024. The Business Value of Gamification. <i>California Management Review.</i>                                                                                                  |           |
|                              | [12] Jacobides, M.G. & <b>Ma, M.D.</b> 2024. Assessing the Expected Impact of Generative AI on the UK Competitive Landscape. <i>UK Government Policy Report.</i>                                                                                         |           |
| SYMPOSIA                     | [13] Jacobides, M.G., <b>Ma, M.D.</b> , Das, A., & Langione, M. 2026. Generative AI Is Not Just Changing Work. It Is Reallocating It. <i>Forbes.</i>                                                                                                     |           |
|                              | Co-organizer, “Diversification in the Digital Age: Should We Rethink Our Premises?”<br><i>Strategic Management Society Annual Conference (October 2024).</i><br>With L. Capron, M.G. Jacobides, G. Lanzolla, C. Markides, P. Puranam, and Y. Romanenkov. |           |
|                              | Co-organizer, “Opening the Black Box of Diversification: Mechanisms and Dynamics”<br><i>Academy of Management Annual Meeting (August 2024).</i><br>With C. Baldwin, C.E. Helfat, M.G. Jacobides, C. Magelssen, and J. Santalo.                           |           |
| AWARDS                       | Academy of Management Robert J. Litschert Best Doctoral Student Paper Award                                                                                                                                                                              | 2026      |
|                              | Academy of Management STR Division Best Paper Award                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2026      |
|                              | Academy of Management William H. Newman Dissertation Award Finalist                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2026      |
|                              | Strategic Management Society Best Paper Prize (Nominee)                                                                                                                                                                                                  | 2026      |
|                              | LBS Sir James Ball Award 25/26 (Runner-Up)                                                                                                                                                                                                               | 2025      |
| GRANTS                       | Noorjehan Pirani PhD Fellowship Award, £10,000                                                                                                                                                                                                           | 2026      |
|                              | LBS Research & Materials Development Grant, £10,000                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 2026      |
|                              | Institute of Entrepreneurship and Private Capital Grant, £9,500                                                                                                                                                                                          | 2024      |
| TEACHING                     | <b>London Business School</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |           |
|                              | Facilitator, Developing Strategy for Value Creation (EMBA)                                                                                                                                                                                               | 2022–2026 |
|                              | Teaching Assistant, Profit, Power & Fairness in the Digital Economy (MBA)                                                                                                                                                                                | 2024–2026 |
|                              | Tutor, Next Generation Digital Strategy (EMBA)                                                                                                                                                                                                           | 2024–2025 |
|                              | Tutor, Aramco Executive Finance Strategy Programme (EMBA)                                                                                                                                                                                                | 2025      |

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| CASE STUDIES | <p>Tanla &amp; Indosat: Building an AI-Powered Shield Against a National Crisis, LBS 2026</p> <p>Building the Phygital Ecosystem: The Journey of Majid Al Futtaim, LBS 2024</p> <p>Facing the Retail Apocalypse: Majid Al Futtaim's Transformation, LBS 2024</p> <p>HDFC ERGO: A Product Ecosystem Built on Mindshare, LBS 2024</p> <p>From PingAn's Inspiration to HDFC ERGO's Journey, LBS 2024</p> <p>From Products to Experience Ecosystems: Haier's Internet of Food, LBS 2022</p> <p>Bridgewater Associates: Chasing Alpha, IESE 2022</p> <p>Technical Note: Central Bank Digital Currencies, IESE 2022</p> <p>Technical Note: Challenger Banks, IESE 2022</p> |                                                                                                                                                  |
| SERVICE      | <p><i>Ad-hoc Reviewer:</i> Industrial and Corporate Change, Long Range Planning</p> <p><i>Conference Reviewer:</i> AOM Annual Conference, Trans-Atlantic Doctoral Conference, LBS Ghoshal Conference, Strategic Management Society Annual Conference</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                                                                                  |
| ADDITIONAL   | <p><b>Citizenship:</b> USA</p> <p><b>Languages:</b> English, Mandarin, Spanish (Intermediate)</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                  |
| SKILLS       | <p><b>Computing:</b> STATA, Python, R, MATLAB, BigQuery, L<sup>A</sup>T<sub>E</sub>X</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                                                                                  |
| REFERENCES   | <p><b>Michael G. Jacobides</b><br/> Sir Donald Gordon Professor of<br/> Entrepreneurship &amp; Innovation<br/> London Business School<br/> mjacobides@london.edu</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | <p><b>Keyvan Vakili</b><br/> Associate Professor of Strategy<br/> &amp; Entrepreneurship<br/> London Business School<br/> kvakili@london.edu</p> |
|              | <p><b>Francisco Brahm</b><br/> Assistant Professor of Strategy<br/> &amp; Entrepreneurship<br/> London Business School<br/> fbrahm@london.edu</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | <p><b>Kristina McElheran</b><br/> Associate Professor of<br/> Strategic Management<br/> University of Toronto<br/> k.mcelheran@utoronto.ca</p>   |

*Updated: 27 August 2026*